Board: 1
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥5

Board: 2
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦A

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦K

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥Q

***Board 1***
West Deals
None Vul

♠ K 5 2
♥ A 9 6
♦ K Q 5
♣ K Q J 2

♠ Q J 9 8
♥ Q 10 3
♦ A 9 4 2
♣ 10 7

♠ 10 4
♥ K J 7 5 2
♦ 10 8 3
♣ 8 5 3

♠ A 7 6 3
♥ 8 4
♦ J 7 6
♣ A 9 6 4

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| Pass | 1♣ | Pass | 1♠ |
| Pass | 2NT | Pass | 3NT |
| All Pass | | | |

3NT by North
Lead: ♥5

This sure looks like an opening 1NT hand, except for one little thing - it is too strong. Make sure you open 1NT **ONLY** with hands containing 15-17 points. For this one you open 1♣. Partner responds 1♠.

Do not support partner's Major suit response with only 3 cards. It is good to raise partner's Major suit **OPENING** with 3 trumps because he guarantees a 5-card suit. As a **RESPONSE** he only promises a 4-card suit, so you should have 4 in the suit to give immediate support.

In fact you have a perfect bid. With a balanced hand and 18-19 points you open 1 of a suit, then jump in Notrump. Holding 18 points you bid 2NT and partner raises to 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥5. West plays the ♥Q.

**North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥5. West plays the ♥Q.**

Winner count: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 4 : Total = 7

You need 2 more winners and they will come from the ♦ suit once you have forced out the ♦A. There is a problem though. When the opponents get the lead with the ♦A they might cash 4 ♥ tricks. Of course if it is West who wins the ♦A and if he doesn't have a ♥ to play then all will be well. So you don't take your ♥A on the first trick, nor do you take it on the second trick. At trick 3 you have no choice so you win your ♥A.

Now you can take your 4 ♣ tricks if you like. Then lead a ♦ honor. If they don't take their ♦A on this trick you play another ♦ honor. One of the defenders will win this trick. If it is West you will make your contract, if it is East you will go down.

Visualize what would happen if you played the ♥A on the first or second trick. When you tried to establish ♦ tricks West would take the ♦A and play a ♥ to East and you would go down 1. By waiting until the third round to take the ♥A you exhaust West of his ♥s.

Notice that if East was the one who had the ♦A then you would go down despite your hold-up play. This PLAN is not a guarantee - but if you follow it you will make the contract 50% of the time. If you don't follow it you will make the contract 0% of the time.

***Board 2***
North Deals
N-S Vul

♠ K 8 6 5
♥ 9
♦ K Q J 4
♣ K J 10 7

♠ A Q J 2
♥ 10 7 4 2
♦ 10 9
♣ A Q 4

♠ 3
♥ A K Q J 8 3
♦ 8 6 3
♣ 9 6 3

♠ 10 9 7 4
♥ 6 5
♦ A 7 5 2
♣ 8 5 2

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 1♦ | 1♥ | Pass |
| 4♥ | | | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♥ by East
Lead: ♦A

With 12 points and an excellent suit you overcall 1♥.

Partner raises to 4♥ and everyone passes.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♦A and the defense wins two high ♦s then switches to a trump.

**East plays 4♥. South leads the ♦A and the defense wins two high ♦s then switches to a trump.**

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 2 : Total = 4

The two ♦ losers are already lost, so you must eliminate a ♣ loser. If South has the ♣K then a simple finesse will win the day. That would be a 50% chance, right? **WRONG!** That would be a 0% chance. You and partner hold 23 HCP. South has already produced 4 HCP with the ♦A, and if he had 3 more that would mean North opened with only 10 points. Very doubtful.

So face it, North has the ♣K.

However, dummy has some nice ♠ cards. So you pull the last trump, play your ♠3 to dummy's ♠A, then lead the ♠Q. If North puts on his ♠K (which you know he must have) you ruff it. Then enter dummy with a ♦ ruff and discard the small ♣ on the good ♠J. If North doesn't play his ♠K you discard your ♣ loser immediately.

If you separate the bidding from the play in your mind you will too often miss clues that should be telling you that certain plans will or won't work.

This was a perfect example. After the opening lead it was easy to deduce that all the rest of the high cards had to be in the North hand.

***Board 3***
South Deals
None Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 9 8 5<br>♥ Q<br>♦ A 7 6 4 3<br>♣ A 10 9 2 | |
| ♠ J 3<br>♥ K 6 5 2<br>♦ K Q J 5 2<br>♣ 6 3 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ Q 10 2<br>♥ 9 8 7 4 3<br>♦ 10 9<br>♣ 8 5 4 |
| | ♠ A K 7 6 4<br>♥ A J 10<br>♦ 8<br>♣ K Q J 7 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1♠ |
| Pass | 3♠ | Pass | 4NT[1] |
| Pass | 5♥[2] | Pass | 6♠ |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by South
Lead: ♦K

You open 1♠ and partner jumps to 3♠.

Wow. It looks like you might have a great fit. You bid 4NT and partner responds 5♥.

Partner shows 2 Aces so you bid 6♠.

South plays 6♠. West leads the ♦K.

**South plays 6♠. West leads the ♦K.**

Losers: ♠ 1? : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 0 : Total = 2?

If trumps don't split 3-2 you will definitely go down 1, so assume they do split. You could finesse East once in ♥s, or use a ruffing finesse on West, but the cleanest approach is just to ruff two ♥s in dummy. Of course you must do this before you pull trumps.

Win the ♦A in dummy. Play the ♥Q to the ♥A and ruff the ♥10 with dummy's ♠8. Play the ♠5 to your ♠A and ruff the ♥J with dummy's ♠9.

Return to your hand with a ♣ and pull another round of trumps with your ♠K. Leaving the master trump out start playing ♣ winners. Someone may ruff with their master trump but that's the only trick they will get.

It was very bold to bid this slam and North/South were fortunate to find a distribution where it could be made.

But that would have been all for nothing if South had not found the PLAN to make it.

***Board 4***
West Deals
Both Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A 3 2<br>♥ Q J 10 7 2<br>♦ J<br>♣ 9 8 6 2 | |
| ♠ K 5<br>♥ A 9 4<br>♦ K 9 8 7 3<br>♣ K 10 5 | | ♠ 9 7 6 4<br>♥ K 8<br>♦ A 10 6 2<br>♣ A Q 3 |
| | ♠ Q J 10 8<br>♥ 6 5 3<br>♦ Q 5 4<br>♣ J 7 4 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1♦ | Pass | 1♠ | Pass |
| 1NT | Pass | 3NT | |
| All Pass | | | |

3NT by West
Lead: ♥Q

With 13 points and 4 of partner's minor suit you may be tempted to say 2NT or 3♦. Both these temptations should be resisted - your first obligation is to show a 4-card Major if you have one. As poor as the suit is, you still respond 1♠.

Partner comes back with 1NT. (Hint: don't rebid the ♠s.)

Partner has 13/14 points and a balanced hand. You have 13 points and a balanced hand. How about 3NT?

East would play 3NT.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♥Q.

**West plays 3NT. North leads the ♥Q.**

Winner count: ♠ 0 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 3 : Total = 7

You need two more winners and you can almost surely get them in ♦s. In fact, if the suit splits 2-2 you could actually get three more winners. But the danger here is that if they **DON'T** split 2-2 and if South happens to win the third ♦ he might lead a ♠. And that might lead to disaster!

Instead, you allow for the possibility that ♦s may not split evenly and you make sure South (the Danger hand) doesn't get the lead. Win the ♥K in dummy. Play the ♦A, (which happens to draw the ♦J from North), then play a small ♦ and finesse with the ♦9. If North can win the trick then the ♦s have split 2-2 and your other 3 ♦s are good. Most importantly though, North cannot lead a ♠ without giving you a trick with your ♠K. If the finesse works, you make 5 ♦ tricks.

Sometimes good play is just visualizing what bad thing might happen.

Here the bad thing would be for South to get the lead and play a ♠. In this case you were able to avoid the bad situation by playing a suit differently than you might have done if there were no danger.